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The appeals of communism: Extracting confessions from the communist subject in the Vietnam war

Oliver Belcher

School of Government & International Affairs, Durham University, Al-Qasimi Building, Elvet Hill Road, Durham, DH1 3TU, UK

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ABSTRACT

This plenary examines the historical relationship between confession, power, and military intelligence in US empire through an analysis of the RAND Corporation's 'Motivation and Morale' Project during the Vietnam War (1964–1968). Drawing on theoretical frameworks from Hannah Arendt, Frantz Fanon, and Michel Foucault, I trace how Western confessional practices evolved from religious to psychological domains, and instrumentalised to unique effect in Cold War military interrogation programs. I focus on the attempt of American social scientists to understand and categorise the 'Communist personality type' through ex-Communist confessional literature and prisoner interviews. I argue that RAND's interrogation methods in Vietnam emerged from this broader intellectual context, reflecting both the period's anti-Communist ideology and colonial power relations. Through extensive archival research, the plenary demonstrates how RAND researchers' attempts to extract 'psychological truths' from Vietnamese prisoners and defectors ultimately produced distorted cultural representations that reinforced American military assumptions. I connect these historical practices to contemporary instances of prisoner interrogation and torture (Guantamano Bay, Abu Ghraib).

This past April, I picked up a book that I had been putting off for some time, Viet Thanh Nguyen's Nothing Ever Dies (2016). I was immediately struck by its first line – an envy of all writers – where Nguyen writes, 'All wars are fought twice, the first time on the battlefield, the second time as memory.' I turned to Nguyen's book at a time of personal dismay I was feeling on the twentieth anniversary of the publication of the Abu Ghraib torture photographs, first released by CBS News on 28 April 2004, but conspicuously absent in news coverage in April 2024.

Twenty years after the fact, it is easy to forget how explosive those photographs were upon their release (Hersh, 2004), how they exposed in full the so-called War on Terror's dark underbelly to a public generally unversed in the lexicon of 'enemy combatants,' and the techniques of 'extraordinary rendition,' 'enhanced interrogation,' and other appellations of the American torture regime at the turn of the new century.

The Abu Ghraib photographs have a personal resonance for me because they formed, in a real way, the foundation and trajectory of my academic career, which I can see clearly in retrospect. I wrote my Master's thesis on Abu Ghraib. My first conference presentation, as well as my first academic article (Belcher, 2008) were on Abu Ghraib. The first 'academic' book I read cover-to-cover was Elaine Scarry's The Body in Pain (1987). And it was in summer 2004 that I first engaged with the writings of Susan Sontag, who remains the most enduring influence on my thinking, and whose work on violence and photography (Sontag, 1979) helped me to make initial sense of what was at stake in the Abu Ghraib photographs. Today, twenty years later, I am presenting yet another project in the shadow of Abu Ghraib, still struggling to make sense of it, still struggling to prevent it from being consigned to the dustbin of history.

Over the past several years, I have been working on a genealogy of Abu Ghraib, as well as Guantánamo Bay, Bagram prison outside of Kabul, and other 'black sites' – tracing the interrogation practices and logistical networks and infrastructure that made such places of torture possible. My interest has primarily been on the relationship between the interrogator and interrogated, the expectations placed on the interrogated in such scenarios, their perceived psychological profiles, and what counts as 'reliable' information or intelligence. This is not as straightforward as it may seem.

For example, when we learn that the psychologists and CIA agents who oversaw 183 episodes of waterboarding on Khalid Shaikh Mohammed at Guantánamo Bay prison, and kept applying the technique to him because he was offering information *about* the September 11th attacks – which he was accused of plotting – *instead* of information related to the CIA's mission of getting '[Mohammed] to reveal details of

E-mail address: oliver.belcher@durham.ac.uk.

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future plots' (Rosenberg, 2024; my emphasis), we can see that what counts as 'good' intelligence is highly contingent. And, of course, the desire to distil and 'exploit' Mohammed's weaknesses, as well as understand his ability to sustain so many waterboarding sessions without 'breaking' placed a special premium on disclosing Mohammed's psychological disposition (cf. Greenberg & Dratel, 2005; McCoy, 2007).

Today, I want to focus on the relationship between the interrogator and interrogated, how the perceived psychological profiles of the other intersects with the extraction of information – even 'truths' – under conditions of duress and torture. To do so, I want to turn our attention to the activity of *confession*, and its peculiar place within the historical repertoire of American intelligence practices. The desire for a confession of a crime or role in a terror attack has long been a central feature of police and intelligence work, obviously not just within the United States, but arguably everywhere. However, what I hope to show today is that the vision and meaning of 'getting a confession' by American interrogators has played a much more complex—perhaps unrivalled—role in the historical carceral economy of American empire.

Recalling the genealogy I've been tracing, I am going to focus on an important precursor to the 'war on terror' torture regime; namely, a prison interrogation programme called the 'Motivation and Morale project' conducted for purposes of military intelligence by the RAND Corporation during the Vietnam War, which ran for four year between 1964 and 1968 (see Elliott, 2010, pp. 45–90; also Davison, 1972; Abella, 2008). RAND is a policy and research institute with a longstanding relationship to the US state, providing in-depth policy-oriented reports and analyses to the US military and other American government entities. In a sense, RAND was the original 'think tank,' and although its influence has waned in recent years, during the Cold War, RAND was at the height of its authority within the US government and military apparatus (Hounshell, 1997), especially concerning theories of nuclear deterrence, limited war, and arms control. In Vietnam specifically, RAND deployed teams of social scientists – anthropologists, psychologists, economists, political scientists, statisticians – to carry out a range of studies on various aspects of the war, from assessing the effectiveness of U.S. bombing campaigns in North Vietnam, to conducting in-depth ethnographies of Vietnamese village and hamlet life (Price, 2016). The Motivation and Morale project, however, was RAND's largest programme in Vietnam, and peculiar insofar as they were granted unprecedented access to Vietnamese prisoners and defectors in order to create a textured picture of the organisational makeup and activities of the Vietnamese National Liberation Front, or 'Viet Cong,' in South Vietnam (Elliott, 2010).[1] Over a four-year period, RAND social scientists and translators conducted over 2400 interviews with prisoners of war and defectors, cutting across different classes in Vietnamese society – peasants, middle class intellectuals, other cadres – in order to better understand the motivations and psychological propensities behind joining the Vietnamese communist movement (Davison, 1972).

At the outset, it is important to highlight the similarities and differences between the Motivation and Morale project and the 'war on terror' torture practices. The similarities are obvious. In both cases, prisoners are interrogated to extract intelligence information; the spatial settings where interrogations took place are inherently coercive; and an emphasis is placed on the psychological motivations of the interrogated subject. The differences, however, are equally important. Prisoners interviewed by RAND were not (directly) tortured by interrogators; the interviews were more wide-ranging than those that seem to have taken place at Abu Ghraib and Guantánamo; and there was a special emphasis placed on *defectors* from the communist movement (part of a U.S.-sponsored Chiêu Hồi/'Open Arms' defection programme) from the communist movement, where confession enters the scene as a way to 'atone' for one's political sins, so to speak, and bring the formerly nonconformist Communist subject back into the social order. I will have more to say about the Motivation and Morale project in the latter half of the talk.

In the meantime, I will proceed as follows. First, I turn to the works of Hannah Arendt, Michel Foucault, and Frantz Fanon to situate 'confession' as a technology of power, and the peculiar function of confession once it moves from a religious practice to a medicalised psychological procedure in the 19th and 20th centuries. In his recently translated psychiatric writings, Fanon proves valuable for understanding the colonial significance of this shift from the religious to the political. Next, I move to the early years of Cold War America, to the height of McCarthyism, to give some context to the RAND project. I am particularly interested in a new genre of writing that emerged during that period; namely, the autobiographical political confessions and fictional works of ex-Communists, who were highly influential in the Cold War American ideological domain. Not only do they remain a touchstone of modern American conservative ideology—which reflexively frames Marxism and Communism as a political religion (Toscano, 2010)—but these confessional accounts were instrumental in how the American intelligence community in general, and RAND in particular, developed methods for interrogating perceived 'Communists.' Finally, I will return to RAND's Motivation and Morale project, its connection to other prisoner interrogation programmes conducted by social scientists in the Malayan Emergency and Korean War, and the application of such methods by American social scientists to understand the appeals of communism among Vietnamese prisoners and defectors.

1. Acts of confession

Let us begin with confession as a concept and procedure of power. Foucault is a good starting point given the exception role he attributed to 'confession' in shaping the contours of Western modernity. 'The confession,' Foucault wrote in *The History of Sexuality* (1978: 59), 'became one of the West's most highly valued techniques for producing truth. We have become a singularly confessing society … Western man is a confessing animal.' Let's pause for a moment on this 'we.' I'm not interested here in rehearsing the accusations around Foucault's supposed 'Eurocentrism' (see Howell & Richter-Montpetit, 2019). Rather, what Foucault provides is an account of confession as it emerged and transformed over time *in the West*. My wager is that this 'Western' practice can tell us something germane when it is instrumentalised to 'understand' *non-Western* subjects and their political motivations in places like Vietnam where, perhaps, confession as truth-telling in recognition of wrongdoing is not assumed as a universal mode of truth-telling. In other words, certain expectations of the confessing subject are brought to bear in those authoritarian situations of the 'Western' interrogator vis-à-vis the extorted 'non-Western' interrogated; between, say, an Ivy League-trained RAND social scientist and a Vietnamese peasant-turned militant cadre.

Unsurprisingly, Foucault traces the confession as a technology of power in the West to its emergence in the first centuries of Christianity, specifically its relationship to penance as an act of remorse or admission of wrongdoing before God (or God's intermediary, the priest), in return—hopefully—for His steadfast love and grace (Foucault, 1978; Foucault, 2021; see also Taylor, 2008). By examining confession as a long-standing truth-procedure of the self in the West, Foucault was able to widen its remit and explore how psychology and psychiatry become 'confessional sciences' in modernity. And he's not the first to see confession as a precursor for modern 'talking therapies,' where a narrative disclosure of one's 'inner life' is seen as a step towards revealing hidden truths, recognising and assuaging guilt, or, in today's parlance, becoming one's 'best self' (Rieff, 1966; Rose, 1996).

For Foucault, the critical matter is how confession incites one's 'inner life' *into discourse*, the putting into words or 'giving an account of oneself' as Butler (2005) once put it, where a bridge is formed between the

[1] 'Viet Cong' is a derogatory epithet initially applied to NLF fighters by the Diem government and adopted by U.S. officials to describe Communist-led insurgents in South Vietnam (see Fitzgerald, 1972).

interiority of the subject and an external power who is interested in that narrativized truth: the priest, psychologist, therapist, interrogator, torturer, God. Of course, the ontology of this confessing subject rests on that old metaphysical assumption of a chiasm between a hidden interior (the soul, mind), separate from, but interconnected with the body. The trick becomes how to *access* this interiority. Confession enters the scene as a procedure for access.

St. Augustine's *Confessions* stands out as a touchstone for placing confession as a central activity of Western subjectivity, despite his curious omission across Foucault's works. Augustine's *Confessions* is commonly cited as the original autobiography because of its intensely personal introspection, with a level of psychological depth and self-examination heretofore unprecedented in ancient literature. Arendt, who wrote her dissertation on Augustine (Arendt, 1998), actually attributes in one of her early writings the *discovery* of the 'inner life' to Augustine due to his stress on memory (i.e., remembering and recounting one's sins or deeds) as a means of self-discovery. According to Arendt, the innovations found in Augustine's *Confessions* went in two directions in the history of western Christianity: one towards the Catholic confessional; the other towards the Protestant notion of 'conscience.'

> By its very nature, the [Catholic] confessional altered the original meaning of confession. In Augustine, the individual who confesses is thrown back into the loneliness of his own inner life and stands with that inner life revealed before God … Augustine confesses to God alone, not to other human beings, though we might possibly say that he confesses for them. The confessional, however, places the authority of the Church between the soul and God, and this is precisely what Luther opposed, regarding it as a distortion of original Christianity. Reaching back over the centuries and past the Catholic era, Luther derived from Augustine his concept of the believer whose conscience stands in direct relationship with God (Arendt, 2005 [1930]: 26–27).

It is precisely this relationship with the other in the confessional, as well as the relationship to conscience, that Foucault brings into focus in his analyses of confession that spanned his four volumes on the history of sexuality and the lectures that supplement that material in the 1970s and 80s (see especially Foucault, 2012).[2] From a broad historical perspective, Foucault traces how confession, as a *procedure* of speaking about one's self, especially one's innermost thoughts and desires to an authoritative other, dispersed across the 19th and 20th centuries into the domains of justice, medicine, education, and intimate relationships at precisely the moment when Christianity was losing its hegemonic hold over culture. Why? Because it was still believed that confession, as a procedure, provided privileged access to the 'truth' of one's inner life.

> [N]ext to the testing rituals, next to the testimony of witnesses, and the learned methods of observation and demonstration, the confession became one of the West's most highly valued techniques for producing truth … The confession … spread its effects far and wide. It plays a part in justice, medicine, education, family relationships, and love relations, in the most ordinary affairs of everyday life, and in the most solemn rites; one confesses one's crimes, one's sins, one's thoughts and desires, one's illnesses and troubles; one goes about telling with the greatest precision, whatever is most difficult to tell. One confesses in public and in private, to one's parents, one's educators, one's doctor, to those one loves; one admits to oneself, in pleasure and in pain, things it would be impossible to tell to anyone else, the things people write books about. One confesses—*or is forced to confess* (my emphasis). When it is not spontaneous or dictated by some internal imperative, the confession is wrung from a person by violence or threat; it is driven from its hiding place in the soul, or extracted from the body. Since the Middle Ages, torture as accompanied it like a shadow, and supported it when it could go no further: the dark twins (Foucault, 1978: 59).

As one would expect with Foucault, confession always takes place within relations of knowledge/power. It requires an authority figure—real or internalised in the confessing subject—who demands, prescribes, and appreciates the confession, who provides a hermeneutic function to decode the 'inner truth' of the subject. And, according to Foucault, a permission structure of 'internal access' to subjective 'truth' emerges when medicalised scientific discourses co-opt Christian procedures of confession during the 19th century. 'It is no longer a question of simply saying what was done … and how it was done,' Foucault writes (1978: 63), 'but of reconstructing, in and around the act, the thoughts that recapitulated it, the obsessions that accompanied it,' and, for my purposes, the *motivations* that went into the act or choice.

Fanon here adds a critical twist to confession as a 'Western' practice; as, perhaps, producing a situation where an impassable gap or chasm manifests itself between the interrogator and interrogated. When Fanon worked as a psychiatrist in Algeria in the 1950s, he was occasionally asked to conduct psychological evaluations for Algerian-Arab perpetrators under, an experience conveyed in a paper delivered (later published with minor modifications) at a psychiatric Congress in Paris in 1955 (Fanon, 2018; Fanon, 2018); cf. Macey, (2000), pp. 197–238). In the paper, Fanon focuses on the concept of *avowal*, a juridical mode of confession in the legal domain, and the complexities that arise for a professional psychiatrist dealing with criminal confession within the colonial context of French-occupied Algeria, specifically the complexities that arise in establishing the 'truth' of a criminal act. As one would expect, Fanon begins with Sartre and ends with Hegel. A Sartrean subject avoids 'bad faith' by acknowledging and taking responsibility for one's actions, an act deemed existentially necessary for maintaining an authentic sense of self and, from the perspective of the law, *reintegration* into society. And, Fanon posits, the psychiatrist's primary role in the confessional situation is to re-establish that civic social contract between a transgressive subject and the law. He writes, 'confession has a moral pole that might be referred to as sincerity. But it also has a civic pole … I confess as a man [sic.] and I am sincere. I also confess as a citizen and I validate the social contract (Fanon, 2018: 415).'

However, in drawing out the existential implications of the confession—its lived experience and meaning—Fanon disrupts the civic presuppositions embedded in the confessional act. After all, from the perspective as a civic-legal act, the fundamental concern of confession is the reproduction of the social contract, what is the meaning of said social contract in a *colonial context* where—and this is where Hegel enters the scene (cf. Fanon, 1952: ch. 7)—racism renders *recognition* impossible between the coloniser and colonised, psychiatrist and criminal, interrogator and interrogated? Even if the accused goes through the motions demanded of the psychiatrist, the gap in recognition already puts the accused in a situation of, in the words of Walter Mignolo (2010), 'epistemic disobedience.'

> The expert cannot deliver the truth of the criminal. Perhaps we could come closer to this ontological system, which escapes us, by asking whether the Muslim native has in fact established a commitment toward this social group, in whose power he is now held. Does he feel bound by the social contract? Does he feel excluded on account of his wrongdoing? And then, from which group? The European group? The Muslim group? What meaning does his crime, the investigation, and lastly sanction now take on (Fanon, 2018: 411)?

In other words, Fanon explodes any notion of a universal subjectivity, especially in a colonial world 'divided in two' (Fanon, 1963, p. 5), where confessional procedures used to diagnose the criminal and

[2] Foucault's 1981 lectures delivered at the Catholic University of Louvain, recently translated into English as *Wrong-Doing and Truth-Telling: The Function of Avowal in Justice* (2012), are especially evocative on the topic of confession, which I sadly had to omit here due to lack of space.

transgressive are 'cross-culturally' inadequate. Foucault would later echo these sentiments in his lectures on *Wrong-Doing and Truth-Telling* (2012), where he closed the 1981 series delivered at the Catholic University of Louvaine with the question: 'In the end, can you condemn to death someone whom you do not know? (Foucault, 2012, p. 283; cf. Lorenzini & Tazzioli, 2016).'

Let's summarise the three key points I've made thus far: (1) the significance of Western modes of confession lies in rendering the so-called 'inner life' into a form of discourse between a self and an authoritative knowing other; (2) the role of the expert-interrogator, the knowing subject, is to interpret and decode the motivations and desires of the known subject, to access via the confession procedure the truth intentionally hidden or unintentionally masked within a subject; and (3) a chasm or gap between the interrogator-interrogated becomes apparent when these procedures of confession and interpretation assume a life and utilised in colonial and postcolonial contexts.

2. Confessing communism

These three dimensions of confession are integral to the pivot I now want to take to the Cold War context, and the emergence of the political confession of Communism. During this time, it must be remembered that Bolsheviks and Communists more generally were perceived (especially in the United States) as a 'New Man,' as the mid-century sociologist Daniel Bell (1955) once put it, a type for which Americans were poorly equipped to understand. In this section of the talk, I want to give a peek into the roles confessional autobiographies and the social sciences had in constituting interrogation practices in Vietnam and elsewhere, in order to make this new 'Communist type' more transparent.

At the outset, I mentioned an utterly unique – and understudied – genre of autobiography that took shape in Europe and North American in the 1940s and 50s: the confessions of former and ex-Communists. Again, Hannah Arendt offers a useful distinction here between 'former' and 'ex-' Communists, with the former signifying party members or fellow travellers who became disillusioned with the excesses of the Soviet revolution and Stalinism,[3] while ex-Communists were something akin to *informants* – rather that merely disillusioned – who in their personal accounts of 'overcoming' the seductions of Communist ideology and public renunciations of the USSR's 'totalitarian' character, became model converts and foot soldiers of 'freedom' in dominant Cold War narratives (Arendt, 1994a, 1994b [1953]: 391–400). It is the confessions of ex-Communist that I focus on here.

Before proceeding, it would be remiss to omit that the 'excesses' of Communism itself had a well-known confessional character, notably in the infamous 'Moscow Trials' that took place in the Soviet Union during the 1930s, which figured so prominently in the Western imagination (cf. Leites & Bernaut, 1954). The Moscow show trials, and later the Chinese Cultural Revolution trials (Thurston, 1984), relied on public self-confessions of prominent Bolshevik leaders accused of conspiring against Stalin's regime, culminating in the widespread repression, indeed elimination, of perceived enemies of the Communist Party. The psychological toll of the Moscow Trials and confessions was powerfully and vividly dramatized in major works of literary fiction from George Orwell's *Nineteen Eighty-Four* (1949) and Czeslaw Milosz's *The Captive Mind* (1953) to Arthur Koestler's Darkness at Noon (1949). Koestler's *Darkness at Noon* in particular gave such a devastating portrait of Stalinist communism in France that it prompted Maurice Merleau-Ponty to write a book-length rebuttal of Koestler's work in *Humanism and Terror* (Merleau-Ponty, 1947). In *Humanism and Terror*, Merleau-Ponty grapples with the moral dilemmas posed by the Soviet regime, including the Stalinist terror methods of self-confession, which he found morally abhorrent, yet still vaguely justified as a necessary means within the revolutionary USSR experiment—a position Merleau-Ponty would abandon a few short years later (Kovaly, 1977).

Despite the well-known confessional character of Stalinism, I want to highlight an equally vociferous confessional moment within 1940s and 1950s America: the confessions of ex-Communists (cf. Hausknecht, 1954). Undoubtedly, the most outstanding example remains Whittaker Chambers' autobiography Witness (1952), the most influential non-fiction work of the twentieth century on the modern American conservative movement (Bennett, 2019; Genter, 2008). In *Witness*, Chambers, an ex-Communist converted to Christianity, portrays communism and Christianity as a cosmic struggle of fundamentally opposed worldviews, with communism's godless vision centred on materialist human progress offering a ontological challenge to America's Christian democratic tradition. Published in 1952, amidst the highly publicised Alger Hiss trial where Chambers accused Hiss of being a Soviet spy, *Witness* reflected the intense anti-communist sentiment of the early Cold War era in the United States—from the character assassinations of suspected communists and spies by Joseph McCarthy and the House Un-American Activities Committee, to the fears of communist 'brainwashing' of otherwise good American men (they were always men), like the sleeper agent Raymond Shaw in *The Manchurian Candidate* (Dunne, 2013; Schreker, 2001).

The ex-Communist confessionals in works such as *Witness* had a two-fold effect. First, they framed communism as a worldview that nefariously penetrated one's *soul*. Chambers depicts communism as a religious anti-religion (see Toscano 2006: 203–247) that preyed on a particular type of person, and the confession worked as a lens to grasp that type. The 1949 collection of six essays by famous ex-Communists, *The God that Failed* (1949; notably subtitled, *A Confession*) is a precursor to Chambers in this genre, and includes essays by Koestler and Richard Wright. (Lest we forget, the protagonist in Wright's *Native Son* (1940), Bigger Thomas, kills the white communist Mary, who poses as a prototype of the 'white saviour'). Second, the ex-Communist confessional self, exemplified in *Witness*, established a fundamental link between identity, ideology, and the individual's relationship to the state. And it was this link – identity, ideology, individual – that RAND social scientists saw as a plane for decoupling the individual from ideology: splitting their identity, so to speak, and making them susceptible to defection *from* communism (e.g., Selznick, 1952). It should be mentioned that this emphasis on confession caused immense anxiety within American society in the 1950s, eventually causing a backlash to McCarthyism. I recommend two Alfred Hitchock films, *I Confess* (1953) and *The Wrong Man* (1956), which deftly capture this social anxiety (Genter, 2012).

During the 1950s, a more 'serious' set of social scientists emerged to understand the 'appeals of communism.' While operating within the same anti-communist milieu, and frequently citing the autobiographical works of Chambers and other ex-Communists, a disparate set of social scientists sought to develop a more 'objective' means of distilling the psychological profile of the Communist 'type.' Two prominent institutional centers stand out: Princeton University's Center for International Studies and the RAND Corporation (see Engerman, 2010). Both institutions fostered an influential set of Russia Studies and Soviet experts, scholars such as Fredrick Dunn, Nathan Leites, Alexander George, Philip Selznick, and Gabriel Almond, among others who are largely forgotten. An exception would be Margaret Mead, the cultural anthropologist who authored the groundbreaking work *Coming of Age in Samoa* (1928), who spent her mid-career as a RAND researcher studying problems of Soviet 'character' and attitudes towards authority (Mead, 1951). Four primary questions motivated this emerging field of Soviet studies: the nuclear question; the foundations and efficiencies of the Soviet economy; the psycho-organizational system of the Communist party; and the personality types susceptible to Communist ideology. It is the research on Communist party organization and 'communist personality types' types that led directly to the interrogation techniques utilised by RAND and US personnel in Vietnam.

There were essentially two competing camps for understanding the

[3] In fact, Arendt and her husband Heinrich Blücher were such 'former Communists.'

appeals of communism: a sociological-institutionalist framework advanced by RAND (later UC-Berkeley) sociologist Philip Selznick, and an socio-personality framework by Princeton's Gabriel Almond (for a critical account, see Mitchell, 1991). Selznick was primarily concerned with the susceptibility of social institutions to ideological manipulation by Soviet-Communist members and ideology. According to Selznick (1952), Communism was taking root in modern societies due to the onset of 'mass behaviour' patterns as a modern social phenomenon. Drawing on existentialist and critical theories, from Ortega y Gasset's *The Revolt of the Masses* (1929) and Fromm's *Escape from Freedom* (1941) to Adorno's *The Authoritarian Personality* (1950), Selznick distrusted the 'masses' as a modern-capitalist phenomenon, arguing that consumer--society's widespread alienation and cultural attenuation resulting from the rise of the 'masses' created a vacuum in which established institutions lost their capacity to transmit and sustain core cultural values effectively. The devaluation of social institutions (e.g., the church, university, civic organisations), created a situation where the masses possessed a superficial adherence to stereotyped cultural values, and culture-sustaining elites in said institutions are debilitated. It is in this devalued work where everything sacred melts into air that the destabilised self becomes susceptible to communism. The exemplar of this phenomenal type is was Selznick calls the 'Stalinoid liberal,' a creature of the educated classes in particular, whom he deems most susceptible to Communist ideology (Selznick, 1952, p. 297). In fact, *all* the anti-Communist studies I've studied, from the confessionals of Chambers and Koestler to the social scientists analysing the appeals of communism, identify middle-class intellectuals—academics essentially—as the susceptible type to Communism.

Here is ACLU lawyer Morris Ernst in his Report on the American Communist (1952: 10):

> The rank and file is almost entirely native-born. Incidentally, it is almost entirely white too … There are several popular stereotypes of the Communist. One is the foreigner, preferably Russian and bearded, with an inbred hatred of American institutions and concealing a bomb. One is an immigrant who has not been well assimilated and fails to understand his new country. One is a victim of poverty or discrimination or both who is driven by economic despair to accept an alien philosophy. One is a psychopathic traitor, a composite figure drawn from the more lurid witnesses in spy trials and the investigations conducted by right-wing anti-Communists with social pink eye. One is a long-haired intellectual who lives in a world of books and talk but never did an honest day's work with his hands. None of these fits the actual rank and file, but the last comes closest to the mark. The party boasts more horn-rimmed glasses with beards, more uncalloused palms than foreign accents.

According to Selznick, the 'Stalinoid liberal'-type drawn to communism is motivated by an alienation from society, a modern phenomenon resulting from social mobility and a levelling of culture in post-war America. 'A major element of the Stalinoid syndrome,' Selznick writes (1952: 299), 'is the feeling of isolation, of anxiety, of the need to find some substitute for older rejected values.' However, the tragic flaw of this type, he argues, is that the Stalinoid liberal fundamentally cannot account for his alienation because they *identify with the mass* via their social-democratic politics. If one hears in Selnick a filiation that runs from idiosyncratic leftists like Christopher Lasch (1995) through contemporary postliberal conservatives like Patrick Deneen (2018) and Vice President JD Vance, they would not be wrong. Selznick's solution? Fortify institutions against Communism and cultural degradation by orienting them back to values of the West, found most notably in the 'classics' of the Western canon.

Gabriel Almond took a different approach. In his book, *The Appeals of Communism* (1954), Almond and his associates conducted a quite extraordinary and nuanced study of the psychological and sociological factors that contributed to individual susceptibility to communist ideology, while diagnosing reasons that led some people to defect from the communist movement. In the study, Almond interviewed 221 former communists from the US, UK, France and Italy. Although it is impossible to summarise this surprisingly rich text, Almond does offer cross-cultural interpretations of the communist appeal. Chief among these for participants were feelings of hostility and resentment towards society or authority figures. For many recruits, Almond argued, the communist movement provided a sanctioned outlet for antagonistic impulses towards social norms, and the party allowed them to frame and situate their personal grievances within a larger ideological struggle. Similarly, individuals grappling with social isolation or loneliness found in Communist organisations a sense of community and belonging that had eluded them elsewhere (Almond, 1954, pp. 230–257).

In the US context, Almond paid particular attention to immigrants, first and second-generation Americans, who he posited were attracted to Communism through a sense of belonging provided by the Party, in a situation otherwise characterised by cultural conflicts felt by many immigrants; e.g., the family dynamics of an immigrant family in a foreign society; identity confusion among children of immigrants caught between two cultures; social isolation; experiences of discrimination; language barriers; etc. However, like others, Almond found middle-class intellectuals to be most susceptible to long-term communist commitment, especially those who, through social mobility from working-class backgrounds, struggled with identity confusion, and sought to resolve these internal conflicts by joining an 'idealist' Party. Almond and his team possessed 35 psychoanalytic case studies of their respondents, which their analysts provided. Almond used these case-studies to produce a typology of maladjusted feelings that made certain 'neurotic' personalities susceptible to communism, like hostility, isolation, self-rejection, resentment.

> It is obvious that all action involves feeling and emotion. In the cases of persons joining the party … alienative (sic.) feelings are typically involved—that is, feelings of rejection, resentment, impulses to attack and withdraw, or some combination of these. Such negative impulses may be party unconscious, chronic, a consequence of the maladjustive (sic.) way in which the individual seeks to relate himself to others, or may be the result of some situational impairment or damage—the consequence, in other words, of some event or development in the neurotic might influence the decision to join the party … In a neurotic person, feelings of confusion, of conflict, and of uncertainty may contribute to the attraction of the party; and confusions and uncertainties which are the consequence of the objective situation in which a normal person finds himself may have the same effect. However, the neurotic person will join the party *in response to the pressure of internal needs* (my emphasis), and often in defiance to modal patterns of his social grouping (Almond, 1954: 235–236).

And, of course, as I have been suggesting throughout this talk, the privileged means of accessing these *internal needs* is via the confession, the interview.

3. Motivation and Morale

The RAND social scientists conducting the Motivation and Morale project in South Vietnam drew directly from Selznick and Almond's work, especially the latter. In the last part of this talk, let me turn to how confession and diagnoses of the 'Communist personality' played out in RAND's programme. The Motivation and Morale project was spearheaded by a Harvard-trained RAND Southeast Asia specialist named Guy Pauker, who recruited Joseph Zasloff, a political science professor at University of Pittsburgh, and Professor John Donnell as principal researchers on the project (Donnell et al., 1965). Zasloff and Donnell designed the methodology for interviewing NLF prisoners and defectors. To do so, they drew on the work by Almond, as well as prisoner interrogation methods developed by another RAND research, Alexander George (1967), as well as MIT Professor Lucian Pye (1956), both of whom interviewed Chinese Communist prisoners in Korea and Malaya

respectively.

George and Pye were friends and colleagues, and both men worked closely with Gabriel Almond, who directly inspired both of them to take his methodological approach into non-Western contexts. George and Pye wrote their books with sincere academic intent, uninterested – at least on the surface – with any 'intelligence value' their work may have had. Pye notes that when trying to establish rapport with prisoners already accustomed to 'lengthy intelligence interrogations,' they disbelieved the idea that he was merely carrying out academic research.

> Some were so at home in the interview situation that on being seated they immediately showed they expected the customary cigarette. The introductory remark that the interview was being conducted in the interest of social science was one attached to an American university, and that it was in no way an intelligence operation, seemed so unlikely and even fantastic to the SEP's that it had to be eliminated for the same of achieving frankness (Pye, 1956: 123).

Both George and Pye drew similar conclusions behind Chinese motivations for joining the Communist party; namely, that the 'weakening of the traditional order … caused by external forces of a modern, industrial character (Pye, 1956, p. 129),' prompted men and and women to join the Party as a means to get ahead in situations where they were otherwise excluded from social mobility. One can see influence of Selznick in this diagnosis of modernity, and it was this approach that most appealed to the Donnell, Pauker, and Zasloff.

As a military contractor, the RAND team was not primarily interested in producing academically rigorous studies, but rather in understanding NLF cadre motivations and organisational capacities, in order to identify *psychological vulnerabilities*. The guiding question behind the programme was one posed by US Defense Secretary Robert McNamara: 'What makes the Viet Cong tick' (Elliott, 2010, p. 49)? RAND researchers travelled to various provinces to interview prisoners and defectors at holding facilities, aiming for geographic and role diversity in their sample pool to answer McNamara's question. Over the duration of the programme, the RAND team interviewed over 2400 Vietnamese prisoners and defectors, generating 62,000 pages of transcripts, and over 35 reports (Davison, 1972: iii).

Obviously, it is impossible to summarise the wealth of detail conveyed in the transcripts. The initial findings of the team came to similar conclusions as George and Pye: Vietnamese peasants were motivated to join the Communist party for purposes of social advancement, as well as a national-anticolonial motivation of expelling the French and Americans (cf. Hunt, 1982, 2014). Such conclusions had little military value, so the researchers began to develop categories and typologies by which to classify the Vietnamese; and, as one would expect, the transcripts and reports traffic in all sorts of cultural binaries and racio-ethnic stereotypes (see Krysa et al., 2016).

However, a year in to the programme, a split began to emerge between the RAND analysts, some of whom began to sympathise with the Vietnamese cause, or at least call into question the dominant American narrative of it, while others saw little intelligence value in the findings (Elliott, 2010, p. 90). In 1966, Zasloff and Donnell were replaced by another RAND researcher named Leon Gouré, who changed the *modus operandi* guiding the interviews. Instead of understanding the psychology of the cadre and the motivations for joining the Communist party, the project was re-oriented towards how US military operations *affected* morale and motivations of the Vietnamese population more broadly. That is, a confirmation bias of military effectiveness began to guide the confessional extractions from prisoners, and the function of the confessions therefore narrowed. Two examples illustrate this shift. In one set of interviews determining the 'effects of defoliation and crop spraying, and some of the dilemmas they raise,' a 'highly experienced' North Vietnam defector stated:

> The Front knows that the purpose of these operations is to defoliate and destroy the base camps of the VC troops. To carry out the Revolution in the South, the Front needs base camps in the mountains and jungles to train and education the troops while they rest. The Front needs to keep a large force in the jungle, and when necessary these troops can be sent down into the plains. If the jungle is destroyed, the Front will have no training camps for its troops. That is why the Front protests so vehemently against defoliation operations – to make the Americans stop spraying chemicals. Besides, when the people's crops are destroyed, the Front won't be able to feed its troops. If the troops are hungry how can they fight? […] From a practical point of view [defoliation operations] destroy the economy and the jungle (Gouré & Thomson, 1965: 17–18)

Another example:

> The bad thing about the Front is that it cannot keep its promises. It is because of the Front that people die in bombings and fighting, and that their families are scattered, their property is damaged, and they cannot till their land. Because of the fact that they cannot till their land, the economic situation (in the rural areas) is deteriorating day by day. In spite of this, the (VC) troop-support tax has become heavier than before (Gouré et al., 1966: 24).

The two confessions reveal two different functions. The first, from the defector, essentially tells the Americans what they want to hear, as a means for atonement and refuge. The second confession reveals a way to extort vulnerabilities, which the interrogators were able to exploit and pass up to their superiors, to more effectively punish the population.

To conclude. To the extent that the Motivation and Morale project produced a picture of the Vietnamese, it was a distorted picture of a culture as backward, irrational, and in need of Western modernisation. Rural Vietnamese were often portrayed as superstitious, ignorant peasants easily manipulated by Communist propaganda. The Communist cadres were depicted as simplistic, ideological, and as either fanatical true believers or cynical opportunists. Little credence was given to the appeal of Vietnamese nationalism or legitimate criticisms of the South Vietnam government. More than anything, it reinforced American policymakers' misguided belief that intensified military firepower and improved propaganda could turn the tide—a conclusion, we know, was flat wrong. More than anything, if the way the ideological epithet 'communist' was used by the Americans both domestically and in Vietnam, it masked the reality that 'most communist prisoners were not immersed in the societal theories of Ho Chi Minh, Mao Zedong or Vladimir Lenin. Instead, they fought for an alternative vision of Vietnamese allegiance and belonging (Berni, 2023, p. 544).'

When we consider the recent revelations of Israeli torture interrogation and abuse of Palestinian prisoners (Yee et al., 2024), perhaps we should ask what epithets are being used to conceal rather than reveal. It was a conceit that the American public has largely never faced; indeed, it was an active dismissal in Abu Ghraib and Guantanamo. Our role is not to give them the satisfaction of forgetting.

Declaration of competing interest

No conflict of interests.

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